In this corpus, the novel 呼兰河传 by 萧红 was used for analysis. It was sourced from qhchina-data/corpora. The novel contains roughly 89,539 Chinese characters, or 58,300 tokens after Jieba dropped punctuation and tokenised it.

The text was first downloaded from qhchina-data/corpora. It then went through normalisation, segmentation, and cleaning. It was converted to simplified Chinese with OpenCC, split into sentences using Chinese sentence-ending punctuation (。！？), tokenised into words with Jieba and had its punctuation removed. Stopwords were also removed using load_stopwords() from qhchina. Each sentence was saved per line, and was kept to at least 5 words, and the words in each sentence were separated by a single space. The result was saved as sentences.txt for later analysis.

In this analysis, the word “我” was chosen as the target word because it symbolises the first-person protagonist in the novel. It had 878 occurrences in the text. For every candidate collocate, a contingency table was built from the four counts: (a) how often the collocate occurs inside the target word’s context region, (b) how often it occurs outside it, (c) the remaining tokens inside the region, and (d) the remaining tokens outside. find_collocates from qhchina was used to find the collocations; each run was done according to a different definition of the aforementioned context region. Two runs were done with a symmetric token window around each occurrence of the target word “我”; one had the range of ±5 and the other ±10. A run was also done at the sentence level. The p-value from Fisher’s exact test indicates how surprising a co-occurrence would be if the collocate were spread randomly. Essentially, it’s a numeric factor for assessing how attracted the collocate is to the target word; the smaller it is, the higher the attraction is.

The three runs yielded 118, 141 and 173 collocates, respectively. While the results ranked differently, a few remain the strongest. These collocates are split into several categories, including family terms, perceptive or cognitive verbs, and environmental nouns. Among the collocates, 祖父 dominates by a wide margin in all runs, indicating the child narrator’s proximity to her grandfather. 祖母 and 母親 are also prominent collocates related to familial relationships, suggesting that the narrator is strongly connected to the family members. The narrator also lives closely with the family, as suggested by environmental nouns such as 家里, 园里, and 后园.

Meanwhile, perceptive or cognitive verbs such as 知道, 觉得, and 看见 are prominent collocates as well. As the novel is narrated in the retrospective voice of a child, these collocates represent the child’s process of developing a sense of self.

A common thread between the aforementioned collocates is that they are all basic terms that revolve around daily life (such as 東西), which imitates the child narrator’s direct perception and understanding of their surroundings. This shows the making of a character-space. As a child, the narrator has a limited understanding of the world around her; her attention hence only travels to the things that she may directly perceive. This is why dialogue verbs, social negotiation or larger-than-life institutions didn’t cluster near 我, while instinctive verbs of observing and interpreting did.

Meanwhile, the character-space is constituted by close familial relations rather than independent attributes, which hones in the narrator’s child perspective. The prominence of

family members places the narrator within a family network, which exists within physical spaces such as a house, a garden or a room — spaces one might call home.

Collocations, in this case, are the building blocks that support a character-space, as they highlight particular relationships and experiences. However, one may only truly grasp how narrative attention is allocated across the novel when collocations are paired with close reading and inspection, since statistical methods alone can't provide further context inside or outside the narrative. For instance, the author's use of alienation in the novel, or its historical background of being written amidst the Second Sino-Japanese War, is crucial information that statistical methods such as collocations cannot capture.

Reading a literary character through collocations has both advantages and limitations. Indeed, collocations are a useful tool. By examining different characters with different window sizes, readers may gain a basic understanding of how a narrative allocates textual attention across characters, events and spaces. Wider windows may admit more items with weaker ratios, while narrower windows concentrate on tighter associations. A different target (such as 祖父 or 园) may reveal attention from the other side, or map the spaces that surround the characters. A different corpus, for instance a third-person novel or prose from the same period, would identify deliberate linguistic choices or thematic continuity across different works of the same author or period of time.

However, collocations alone are merely data — they could only reveal numeric facts of a piece of text. Within the narrative, they cannot capture irony, narrative perspective, plot development, or the full complexity of character relations independently. Broader historical backgrounds or literary movements are also left out. To circle back to Woloch's framework, collocations undeniably map the space a character occupies within a narrative, pointing out where attention concentrates. Yet, what that attention does, or the meaning behind it, would be lost if collocations are the sole lens for reviewing literary characters